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Invariants, monovariants and extremal arguments

Level 4 Olympiad · Combinatorics

How to prove that a process can never reach a state, that it must stop, or that a configuration has a property, by finding the right quantity or the right extreme object.

By the end you can: You will be able to find invariants (parity, residues, products, colourings, weighted sums) and use them to prove impossibility.; You will be able to prove that a process terminates using a bounded integer monovariant, and pair it with a strategy to find a maximum number of moves.; You will be able to choose an extreme object and turn what it forces into a complete olympiad proof..

Lesson

Three frogs sit on the number line at 0, 1 and 3. A move: one frog jumps over another frog and lands the same distance beyond it, so a frog at x jumping over a frog at y lands at $2y - x$. Can the frogs ever sit at 10, 11 and 12?

You could play for a while, and the frogs wander all over the line. But watch a single frog: it goes from x to $2y - x$, and $2y - x$ has the same parity as x. So each frog keeps its parity for ever. At the start two frogs are on odd numbers and one is on an even number; at 10, 11, 12 two would be on even numbers. Impossible, and no amount of experimenting would have told you that.

That is the whole unit in miniature. When a problem describes a process (moves, operations, a game, a sequence of choices) you do not try to follow every possible history. You find one quantity that behaves predictably under every move, and let it do the work.

Invariants

Invariant principle. Suppose a process moves between states, and I is a quantity computed from the state with $I(\text{after}) = I(\text{before})$ for every legal move. Then every state reachable from the starting state S_0 has $I = I(S_0)$. In particular, if $I(T) \neq I(S_0)$, the state T cannot be reached.

The proof is induction on the number of moves, and nobody will ask you for more than that sentence. The difficulty is always in finding I. The usual candidates, roughly in the order to try them:

- parity, or a residue modulo some m (work out what the move does mod 2, 3, 4, and so on);
- a sum, a product, or a sum of squares of the numbers involved;
- a colouring: label the positions so that each move touches the colours in a fixed pattern;
- a weighted sum $\sum w_i c_i$, with weights chosen so that the effect of a move cancels.

Two habits matter. First, compute what the move does to a candidate quantity in general, not on one example. Second, remember that an invariant only ever proves that something is *impossible*. If the answer is "yes, it can be done", you must show how.

Example 1. A machine holds a pair of positive integers, starting with $(1, 2)$. In one step it replaces (a, b) by either $(a + 2b,\ b)$ or $(a,\ b + 2a)$. Can the machine ever hold $(60, 210)$? What about $(2025, 2026)$? And $(13, 2)$?

Solution.

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The sum is no use: it just grows. So look at the numbers modulo something small. The first kind of step changes a by $2b$, which is even, and leaves b alone; the second changes b by $2a$ and leaves a alone. So a is always odd and b is always even. That rules out $(60, 210)$ at once.
The pair $(2025, 2026)$ passes this test. It also passes sharper ones. Since b is even, $2b$ is a multiple of 4, so in fact $a \equiv 1 \pmod 4$ for ever, and $2025 \equiv 1 \pmod 4$. Also $\gcd(a + 2b, b) = \gcd(a, b)$, so the gcd stays equal to 1, which is true of 2025 and 2026. Every invariant we can think of says "maybe". This is the moment to stop hunting for invariants and look at the move itself.
After any step, the entry that was just changed is more than twice the other one, because $a + 2b > 2b$ and $b + 2a > 2a$. So every pair the machine reaches, apart from the starting pair, has one entry more than double the other. But $2025 < 2 \cdot 2026$ and $2026 < 2 \cdot 2025$, so $(2025, 2026)$ is unreachable.
The same observation tells you how to test any target: run the machine backwards. The last step must have increased the larger entry, so the previous pair is forced. From $(13, 2)$ we go back to $(9, 2)$, then $(5, 2)$, then $(1, 2)$, so $(13, 2)$ is reachable in three steps.

Notice the shape of that example. Invariants gave necessary conditions; a different argument (looking at the last move) was needed to finish. Contest problems are often built exactly like this.

Example 2. The hundred numbers $\frac{1}{4}, \frac{1}{6}, \frac{1}{8}, \ldots, \frac{1}{202}$ are written on a board. A move: erase two numbers a and b and write $a + b - 2ab$. After 99 moves one number is left. Show that it does not depend on the order of the moves, and find it.

Solution.
The question promises an invariant, but the sum is not one, because of the $-2ab$. When an operation has the shape "sum minus a multiple of the product", try to factorise. Here

$$(1 - 2a)(1 - 2b) = 1 - 2a - 2b + 4ab = 1 - 2(a + b - 2ab).$$

So if we replace each number x by $1 - 2x$, the move becomes: erase two numbers and write their product.
Hence $P = \prod(1 - 2x)$, taken over the numbers on the board, is invariant. For $x = \frac{1}{2k+2}$ we get $1 - 2x = \frac{k}{k+1}$, so at the start

$$P = \frac{1}{2} \cdot \frac{2}{3} \cdot \frac{3}{4} \cdots \frac{100}{101} = \frac{1}{101}.$$

If N is the final number then $1 - 2N = \frac{1}{101}$, so $N = \frac{50}{101}$, whatever the order of the moves.

Monovariants

Sometimes nothing is preserved, but something only ever moves one way. Typical questions: "prove that the process must stop", "prove that eventually ...".

Monovariant principle. If V is a non-negative integer and every move decreases V by at least 1, then the process stops after at most $V(S_0)$ moves. Likewise, if V is an integer that increases by at least 1 with every move and never exceeds a fixed number B, then at most $B - V(S_0)$ moves are possible.

Proof: after k moves, $V \le V(S_0) - k$, and $V \ge 0$, so $k \le V(S_0)$. The integrality matters. A real quantity can decrease for ever (think of $1, \frac{1}{2}, \frac{1}{3}, \ldots$), so if your V is not an integer you need another reason why it cannot keep decreasing, for instance that there are only finitely many states and none can repeat.

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Example 3. Finitely many integers are written on a board. A move: choose two of them, a and b, with $a \geq b+3$, erase them and write $a-1$ and $b+2$. Prove that, however the moves are chosen, the process must stop.

Solution.
The move pulls two numbers towards each other, so the natural first guess is the sum of squares, which measures spread. Test it. With $a = 10$, $b = 0$ the sum of squares goes from 100 to $81 + 4 = 85$, which is good; but with $a = 4$, $b = 1$ it goes from 17 to $9 + 9 = 18$. It can go up, so it is not a monovariant.
Look at what the move does to simpler things. The sum goes up by exactly 1, since $(a-1)+(b+2) = a+b+1$. An increasing integer is fine as long as it is bounded, so we want a bound. Let M be the largest number at the start. In a move, $a-1 < a \leq M$ and $b+2 \leq a-1 < M$, so the largest number on the board never increases, and every number stays at most M.
If there are n numbers (the move does not change how many), the sum is therefore always at most nM. It starts at some integer S_0 and goes up by 1 with each move, so at most $nM - S_0$ moves can be made. The process stops.

The lesson: a monovariant is often a dull quantity (here the sum) together with a bound that comes from somewhere else.

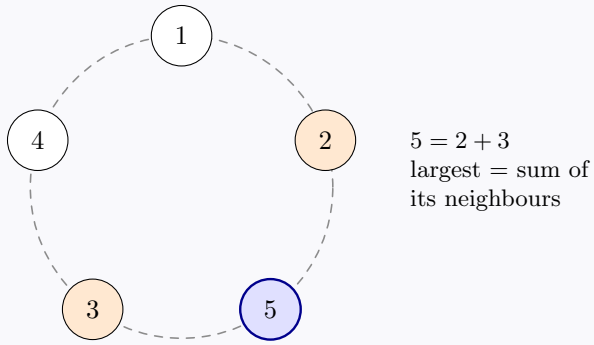
The extremal principle

Extremal principle. Every non-empty finite set of real numbers has a largest and a smallest element, and every non-empty set of positive integers has a smallest element. So in any finite configuration you may pick an extreme object (largest number, shortest cycle, closest pair, leftmost point) and ask what its extremeness forces.

This is the same idea as induction and infinite descent: "take a smallest counterexample" is an extremal argument. The skill is choosing which extreme to look at. If one choice tells you nothing, try another.

Example 4. At least three distinct positive integers are arranged around a circle so that each one divides the sum of its two neighbours. Prove that the smallest number divides every number on the circle.

Solution.
First get examples. With three numbers $x < y < z$: z divides $x+y$, which is positive and less than $2z$, so $x+y = z$; then y divides $x+z = 2x+y$, so y divides $2x$, which is less than $2y$, giving $y = 2x$. So three numbers must be $x, 2x, 3x$. A bigger example is $1, 2, 5, 3, 4$ in that order around the circle: $1 \mid 6$, $2 \mid 6$, $5 \mid 5$, $3 \mid 9$ and $4 \mid 4$.



In that example the largest number, 5, is the sum of its neighbours. That is the extreme to

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look at. Let M be the largest number and a, b its neighbours. They are smaller than M, so $0 < a + b < 2M$, and $M \mid a + b$ forces $a + b = M$.
Now suppose there are at least four numbers, and remove M, so that a and b become neighbours. Does the property survive? The other neighbour of a is some c, and $c \neq b$ because there are at least four numbers. Before, $a \mid M + c$; now we need $a \mid b + c$. But $b + c = (M + c) - a$, so yes. The same works for b, and nobody else's neighbours have changed.
So we induct on the number n of integers. For $n = 3$ they are $x, 2x, 3x$ and the smallest, x, divides all of them. For $n \geq 4$, remove the largest number $M = a + b$. The remaining $n - 1$ numbers are distinct and still have the property, so by induction their smallest, m, divides all of them, in particular a and b; hence $m \mid M$. Since M was the largest, m is also the smallest of all n numbers. This completes the induction.

The extremal choice did two jobs: it gave a concrete equation ($M = a + b$) and it pointed to the reduction (remove M).

Common traps.

- Using an invariant to "prove" that something is possible. Invariants only rule things out; a "yes" needs a construction.
- Checking a quantity on one or two sample moves and declaring it invariant. Write down the change for a general move, and check every type of move, including moves at the ends of a row or across the join of a circle.
- A monovariant that is not an integer, or is not bounded. Decreasing is not enough on its own.
- Taking "the largest" element of a set that might be infinite. The extremal principle needs the extreme object to exist.
- In a write-up, forgetting to state the invariant clearly, compute it at the start and at the target, and say why the two values differ.

How to spot this in a contest

The words "a move consists of", "repeatedly", "is it possible to reach", "whatever choices are made" or "prove that the process terminates" are a direct invitation: look for an invariant when the question is about reaching a state, and a monovariant when it is about stopping. Start by doing a few moves by hand and writing down what changes and what does not, then test parity, residues, sums, products and colourings, in roughly that order.

When the problem is a fixed configuration and asks you to prove that something exists, or that every element has some property, reach for the extremal principle: take the largest, smallest, shortest or closest object and see what it forces. If a problem asks for the largest possible number of moves, you usually need both halves: a monovariant for the upper bound and a careful strategy that achieves it.

Practice

Try each problem before turning to the hints and solutions at the back.

1. ⋆ The numbers $1, 2, 3, \ldots, 10$ are written on a board. A move: choose two numbers a and b, erase them, and write $\dfrac{ab}{a+b}$. After nine moves a single number remains. Find it.

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2. ⋆⋆ Twelve lamps stand in a circle, all switched off. A move: choose three consecutive lamps and switch each of them (on becomes off and off becomes on). How many of the $2^{12} = 4096$ on/off patterns can be reached?

3. ⋆⋆ A word is made of the letters A and B. A move replaces some occurrence of AB (an A immediately followed by a B) by BAA. Prove that, starting from any word, one cannot make moves for ever, and that the number of moves made before no move is possible does not depend on the choices.

4. ⋆⋆⋆ Ten coins lie in a row, all showing heads. A move: choose a coin showing heads, turn it over, and also turn over the coin immediately to its right, if there is one. Prove that the moves must eventually stop, and find the largest possible number of moves.

5. ⋆⋆⋆ In a chess tournament with $n \geq 3$ players, every two players played each other exactly once and no game was drawn. Every player won at least one game. Prove that there are three players A, B, C such that A beat B, B beat C and C beat A.

6. ⋆⋆⋆⋆ Six bowls stand in a circle. One of them, bowl A, contains a single bean, and the others are empty. A move: take a bean out of any bowl and put one bean into each of the two neighbouring bowls. Prove that the bowl opposite A can never contain more beans than the other five bowls together.

Contest ladder

Real past problems that use this idea, easiest first. Open them on the official paper or the AoPS wiki, or online at kevinvariant08.github.io.

1. AMC 10B 2013 Problem 17 ⋆
2. AMC 10B 2024 Problem 16 ⋆⋆
3. BMO Round 1 2011/12 Problem 4 ⋆⋆
4. BMO Round 1 2023/24 Problem 2 ⋆⋆
5. AIME I 2012 Problem 11 ⋆⋆⋆
6. USAJMO 2013 Problem 2 ⋆⋆⋆
7. USAJMO 2020 Problem 1 ⋆⋆⋆
8. BMO Round 1 2019/20 Problem 5 ⋆⋆⋆
9. USAJMO 2019 Problem 1 ⋆⋆⋆⋆
10. USAJMO 2015 Problem 6 ⋆⋆⋆⋆
11. BMO Round 1 2025/26 Problem 6 ⋆⋆⋆⋆

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Hints

1. What happens to the reciprocal of the new number?
2. Label the lamps 0 to 11 and group them by their label modulo 3. How many lamps of each group does one move switch? For the construction, see what two overlapping moves do together.
3. Give each A the weight 2^k, where k is the number of Bs to its right, and add up the weights.
4. Give the coins weights $10, 9, \ldots, 1$ from left to right and add up the weights of the coins showing heads. For the construction, which head should you choose so that this total drops as slowly as possible?
5. First show that there is a cycle of players, each of whom beat the next, the last having beaten the first. Then take the shortest such cycle.
6. Look for weights $w_0, \ldots, w_5$ on the bowls such that a move never changes $\sum w_i c_i$. A move at bowl k removes w_k and adds $w_{k-1} + w_{k+1}$.

Solutions

Problem 1

Answer: 2520/7381

Since $\dfrac{a+b}{ab} = \dfrac{1}{a} + \dfrac{1}{b}$, the reciprocal of the new number is the sum of the reciprocals of the two erased numbers. So the sum of the reciprocals of the numbers on the board is invariant. At the start it is

$$1 + \frac{1}{2} + \frac{1}{3} + \cdots + \frac{1}{10} = \frac{7381}{2520}.$$

At the end it is $\frac{1}{N}$, where N is the last number. Hence $N = \dfrac{2520}{7381}$, whatever moves are made.

Problem 2

Answer: 1024

Label the lamps $0, 1, \ldots, 11$ around the circle and put lamp i in class i mod 3, so each class has four lamps. Three consecutive labels have three different residues modulo 3, and this is still true across the join (for example $11, 0, 1$ have residues $2, 0, 1$) because 12 is a multiple of 3. So every move switches exactly one lamp in each class, and the parities of the numbers of lit lamps in the three classes all change together. At the start all three parities are even, so in every reachable pattern the three classes have lit-lamp counts of the same parity.

The number of patterns with this property is $2 \cdot 8^3 = 1024$: choose the common parity, and then each class of four lamps has 8 subsets of that parity.

Conversely, all of these can be reached. The moves on lamps $i, i+1, i+2$ and on $i+1, i+2, i+3$ together switch only lamps i and $i+3$. Doing this for i and then for $i+3$ switches lamps i and $i+6$, and so on, so we can switch any two lamps of the same class and leave everything else unchanged. If a target pattern has an even number of lit lamps in every class, pair up its lit lamps within each class and switch the pairs. If it has an odd number in every class, first make the move on lamps $0, 1, 2$; the lamps that still differ from the target now form an even number in every class, and we finish as before. So exactly 1024 patterns are reachable.

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Problem 3

For each letter A in the word, let k be the number of letters B to its right, and give that A the weight 2^k. Let W be the sum of the weights of all the As.

We claim W is invariant. Consider a move replacing AB by BAA, and suppose the A in the block has k Bs to its right; $k \geq 1$ because of the B right after it. After the move, the block reads BAA, and each of the two new As has $k-1$ Bs to its right, so their total weight is $2 \cdot 2^{k-1} = 2^k$, the same as before. Every A to the left of the block still has the same number of Bs to its right (the B has only moved within the block), and every A to the right of the block is unaffected. So W does not change.

Each move increases the number of As by exactly one. On the other hand every weight is at least 1, so the number of As is always at most W. If a_0 is the number of As at the start, at most $W - a_0$ moves can be made, so the process cannot go on for ever.

When no move is possible, the word contains no AB, so it has the form $\mathrm{B}\ldots\mathrm{BA}\ldots\mathrm{A}$. Then every A has weight $2^0 = 1$, and the number of As equals W. Since the number of As went up by one per move, the number of moves made is exactly $W - a_0$, which depends only on the starting word.

Problem 4

Answer: 55

Number the coins 1 to 10 from left to right and give coin i the weight $11 - i$. Let W be the total weight of the coins showing heads; at the start $W = 10 + 9 + \cdots + 1 = 55$.

Consider a move on coin i, which shows heads. If $i = 10$, only coin 10 turns over and W drops by 1. If $i \leq 9$, coin i turns to tails, losing $11 - i$, and coin $i+1$ turns over. If coin $i+1$ was tails, W changes by $-(11-i) + (10-i) = -1$; if it was heads, W changes by $-(11-i) - (10-i) = -(21-2i) \leq -3$. So every move decreases W by at least 1. Since W is a non-negative integer, at most 55 moves can be made, and in particular the moves must stop.

To make 55 moves, always choose the rightmost coin showing heads. The coin to its right, if there is one, shows tails, so by the calculation above W drops by exactly 1. This can be repeated as long as some coin shows heads, that is, as long as $W > 0$. So we make exactly 55 moves, and the answer is 55.

Problem 5

Call a sequence of distinct players $Q_1, Q_2, \ldots, Q_k$ with $k \geq 2$ a *cycle* if Q_1 beat Q_2, Q_2 beat Q_3, and so on, and Q_k beat Q_1.

First, a cycle exists. Start with any player P_1. Since every player won a game, P_1 beat some P_2, who beat some P_3, and so on. There are finitely many players, so some player appears twice; take the first repetition $P_j = P_i$ with $i < j$. Then $P_i, P_{i+1}, \ldots, P_{j-1}$ are distinct and form a cycle. Its length is not 1, since nobody plays themselves.

Now choose a cycle $Q_1, \ldots, Q_k$ of smallest possible length. Two players play only once, so $k = 2$ is impossible, and $k \geq 3$. Suppose $k \geq 4$ and look at the game between Q_1 and Q_3. If Q_3 beat Q_1, then Q_1, Q_2, Q_3 is a cycle of length $3 < k$. If Q_1 beat Q_3, then $Q_1, Q_3, Q_4, \ldots, Q_k$ is a cycle of length $k-1$. Either way we contradict the minimality of k. Hence $k = 3$, and $A = Q_1$, $B = Q_2$, $C = Q_3$ are the required players.

Problem 6

Number the bowls $0, 1, \ldots, 5$ around the circle, with A as bowl 0, so that bowl 3 is opposite A, and indices are read modulo 6. Let c_i be the number of beans in bowl i.

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A move at bowl k changes a weighted sum $\sum w_i c_i$ by $w_{k-1} + w_{k+1} - w_k$, so we want weights with $w_k = w_{k-1} + w_{k+1}$ for every k. Taking $w = (1, 0, -1, -1, 0, 1)$ works: one checks $w_5 + w_1 = 1 = w_0$, $w_0 + w_2 = 0 = w_1$, $w_1 + w_3 = -1 = w_2$, $w_2 + w_4 = -1 = w_3$, $w_3 + w_5 = 0 = w_4$ and $w_4 + w_0 = 1 = w_5$. Hence

$$I = c_0 - c_2 - c_3 + c_5$$

is unchanged by every move. At the start $I = 1$, so at every later stage

$$c_3 = c_0 + c_5 - c_2 - 1 \leq c_0 + c_5 - 1 < c_0 + c_1 + c_2 + c_4 + c_5.$$

So bowl 3 always contains fewer beans than the other five bowls together.

(The weights were found by solving $w_{k+1} = w_k - w_{k-1}$: any starting pair $1, x$ gives the sequence $1, x, x-1, -1, -x, 1-x$, which repeats with period 6, so it fits round the circle. The choice $x = 0$ happens to give the cleanest inequality.)

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